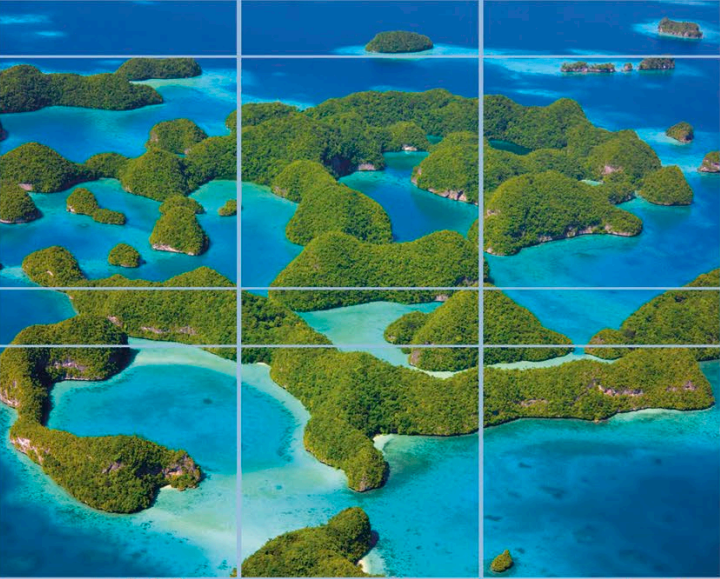


AUSTRALASIA & OCEANIA

Unknown to the outside world before the 17th century, Australia is a still a sparsely inhabited land where most people live in cities. At its heart is a great arid desert, in stark contrast to the islands of Oceania where all life revolves around the glittering ocean. The 3,000 named islands are grouped into nations, listed below in order of land area.

Australia   2,988,902 sq miles 7,741,220 sq km  22,993,000  Canberra  English, Italian, Cantonese, Greek, Arabic, Vietnamese, Aboriginal languages	The thickly wooded Rock Islands of Palau near the Philippines are ancient reefs raised above sea level, fringed by coral sand beaches and blue lagoons.				Micronesia   271 sq miles 702 sq km  104,700  Palikir  Trukese, Pohnpeian, Kosraean, Yapese, English
	New Zealand   103,363 sq miles 267,710 sq km  4,474,000  Wellington  English, Maori				Palau   177 sq miles 459 sq km  21,300  Melekeok  Palauan, English, Japanese, Angaur, Tobi, Sonsorolese
Papua New Guinea   178,704 sq miles 462,840 sq km  6,791,000  Port Moresby  Pidgin English, Papuan, English, Motu, 800 (est) native languages	Solomon Islands   11,157 sq miles 28,896 sq km  635,000  Honiara  English, Pidgin English, Melanesian Pidgin, c. 120 other languages	Fiji   7,056 sq miles 18,274 sq km  915,300  Suva  Fijian, English, Hindi, Urdu, Tamil, Telugu	Vanuatu   4,706 sq miles 12,189 sq km  277,600  Port-Vila  Bislama (Melanesian Pidgin), English, French, other indigenous languages	Kiribati   313 sq miles 811 sq km  106,900  Bairiki (Tarawa atoll)  English, Kiribati	
			Samoa   1,093 sq miles 2,831 sq km  198,900  Apia  Samoan, English	Tonga   288 sq miles 747 sq km  106,500  Nuku'Alofa  English, Tongan	
			Sydney's iconic Opera House and Harbor Bridge symbolize this Australian city's role as a center of global culture.		Marshall Islands   70 sq miles 181 sq km  73,300  Majuro  Marshallese, English, Japanese, German